They were wrong. After a tumultuous three-month campaign, one analyst would dub it the “Seinfeld election”. In other words it was about nothing at all—except, perhaps, for the social and cultural schisms between Israelis, and the political system’s inability to resolve them.

Religion and state

A few years ago, in a Middle Eastern country, the conservative-led government was debating a fundamental change in the state’s founding document, a constitutional amendment that would have subjugated civil law to religion, forcing judges and legislators to consider ancient texts in their debates over, say, the rights of women. The debate over the measure was so fierce that it eventually brought down the government.

This was Egypt in 2012, when the Muslim Brotherhood was in power. Then it happened again, two years later—in Benjamin Netanyahu’s Israel.

Israel has long defined itself as a “Jewish and democratic state”, a concept enshrined in several of the country’s “basic laws”, which serve as a *de facto* constitution. The idea has always been riddled with contradictions. Until 1966 the Arab minority lived under martial law (though it was also allowed to vote, and to field candidates for the Knesset). Civil marriage is still forbidden, which clearly privileges the Jewish over the democratic, even though a solid majority of Israelis support it.[8]

The contradiction stems in part from Judaism’s unique status as both a national identity and a religion. Some supporters argue that a Jewish and democratic state is no different than a French and democratic one: both grant equal rights to all citizens, but reserve certain privileges (like immigration) to members of a particular group. Yet in the Western world that Israel often cites as a model, national identities are becoming more malleable. An Algerian Muslim will find systemic discrimination in France, and a German immigrant in Paris might find it awkward to sing *La Marseillaise*, a strident anthem about “soaking our fields” in Prussian blood. But both can become French in a way they cannot become Jewish.

“How can Israel say that everyone is equal before the law, that you’re equal before the law, when the law defines Judaism as the cultural, national and legislative basis for the state?” asked Yair Lapid at a 2013 conference on Arab participation in the economy. He called the rift between Jewish and democratic an unsolvable problem. “We all pretend that if there’s a